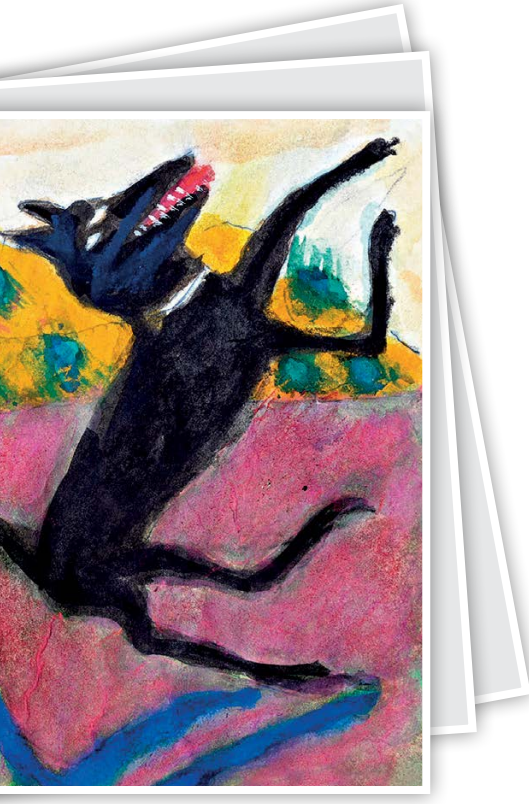


'Who is the Boss', watercolour on paper, 2024

THE PAINTINGS INCLUDED IN THIS EXHIBITION WERE DRAWN FROM SCENES THE ARTIST OBSERVED SITTING IN HIS GARDEN—BIRDS, TREES AND LOTS OF MONKEYS

agery similar to Bengal School paintings, but eventually moved on from the exercise. In the 1970s, as he became more confident in his own style, Ambalal started to interact with Indian artists like Bhupen Khakhar and Vivan Sundaram. By then, Ambalal had also figured out how to incorporate the influences of international artists he admired (Marc Chagall, Joan Miró)—and to make those influences his own, creating a wholly new, original voice.

"See, I am a figurative artist," says Ambalal. "So the artists who I liked from an early age were figurative artists as well. I liked Chagall because unlike most examples of high art, his paintings did not bore me. Having said that, I do enjoy the works of Bhupen Khakhar, Jogen Chowdhury, Arpita Singh and a few others. I look at these people not only as colleagues and friends but also as ideological allies."

In the Garden of Sumeru derives its name from Ambalal's familial house, which is called 'Sumeru'. Built by the French-American architect Bernard Kohn, the house's sloping walls invoke mountains; 'Sumeru' being derived from the mythical mountain Meru, of course. The paintings included in this exhibition were drawn from scenes the artist observed sitting in his garden—birds, trees and lots of monkeys. Accordingly, there are a fair number of monkey paintings, like the eye-catching array of nine paintings called 'The Take Off' (watercolour on paper, 12x16 inches each). The paintings present an intense, dynamic view of a monkey (drawn blue, and clearly a grey langur) in the various stages of a mighty leap. 'Calligraphy of Love' (watercolour on paper, 12.5x16 inches) displays a similar attentiveness to the 'poetry of locomotion', intense overlapping strokes in primary colours suggesting rapid motion, this time on the part of an affectionate dog licking a woman's face.

"At this stage of my career, I just want to enjoy the process," says the 81-year-old Ambalal. "The work should have some lightness in it, it shouldn't be bogged down by sentimental drama or other kinds of discourse. Otherwise, the painting becomes a literary text, or an illustration for a text. The painting should remain a painting." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha





While some old themes remain, Burman has noticed a shift in her visual language—"a result of my journey with spirituality"

collection of shells and cowries, mythological stories about goddess Lakshmi and many other thoughts have led her to create this immersive journey that explores the cosmic connection of stars and water bodies, the harmony of colours and the expanse of mystical landscapes.

Female figures have played a prominent part in her works and they make their presence felt here as well in watercolour paintings titled 'Weeping Grace', while cowries and shells—symbols of fertility and abundance—adorn their long flowing hair, or lie scattered on the canvas in 'Ocean's Whisperers'.

Art curator and writer Premjish Achari believes that Burman's works invite viewers to speculate about the meaning of various elements within a painting. "This speculative possibility allows the exploration of alternative realities beyond the confines of the canvas," he says.

While some themes and imagery remain a part of her works, Burman herself has noticed a shift in her visual language—"a result of my journey with spirituality and bhakti". Her cosmic journey, she believes, has led her to create works which come from her head, heart and emotions. "It's all coming together now and I can feel that change within me," she says. "The impressions that I have carried within myself since childhood have taken shape in my works. I wish to explore the nuances of the unconscious while remaining true to contemporary issues." ■

–Deepali Dhingra

The Whisper of Water, The Song of Stars is on at Art Alive Gallery, New Delhi till February 28, 2025